

POL40970 - The Politics of European Governance

Dr. James P. Cross

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Term 1



Introduction

The European Union (EU) currently consists of 27 European countries. It has evolved into a political community that deeply affects the daily lives of its citizens. How can we explain the process of European Integration? What does the political structure of the EU look like? The module surveys the development of European integration and introduces students to the EU's political system. We will discuss theories of European integration and examine major challenges, that the EU faces at the beginning of the 21st century. The module is research lead, in that it focuses upon the political science literature that seeks to explain various aspects of European integration. This is reflected in the extensive reading list provided with the module.

The module is aimed at those wanting a full and detailed introduction to (1) the history and theories of European integration; (2) the political institutions of the EU and its policy-making process; and (3) current and future challenges facing the EU as a political system. The module does not assume any prior knowledge of the EU or EU politics.

Module structure

The module adopts a seminar format, placing significant responsibility on students to direct individual class sessions. This approach necessitates extensive reading, critical reflection, and regular articulation of your understanding of the material. Each week, different student groups will lead the discussion, preparing a presentation to introduce the topic to their peers and facilitating the seminar for the first hour. The module culminates in a final group project, which serves as the end-of-module assessment. Further details regarding assessment requirements are provided in subsequent sections.

Learning outcomes

At the end of this module students will be able to:

- Trace and analyse the historical evolution of European integration, from the European Coal and Steel Community to the contemporary European Union.
- Evaluate the interplay and policy-making processes of the EU's three main legislative institutions.
- Apply diverse theoretical frameworks to critically assess European integration.
- Examine and compare various EU policy domains, assessing the Union's role and effectiveness in each area.
- Articulate and communicate complex concepts related to European integration, both orally and in writing.
- Critically evaluate current challenges facing the EU and project future scenarios, drawing on theoretical perspectives covered in the module.
- Develop research and analytical skills through engagement with academic literature on European politics and governance.

- Enhance collaborative and presentation skills through group projects and seminar leadership.

Module assessment

Module grading scheme

- Running a seminar: 25% (includes outline & materials)
- ParliView diary study: 25%
- Research paper: 50%

Important dates

- **23 October 2025:** ParliView workshop
- **6 November 2025:** Diary study due
- **4 November 2025:** Assignment plan due
- **5 December 2025:** Final paper due

Student-led seminar

Students will be required to lead discussion as part of a group once during the semester. Each group will conduct a student-led simulation of an EU policy process relevant to their assigned week's topic. Each group should contact the lecturer in the week before their presentation to discuss options and plans.

Seminar Structure and Requirements

Part 1: In-Class Exercise (First Hour of class) Each group must prepare and deliver a hands-on simulation exercise that runs for the first hour of their allocated seminar. This exercise should:

- Simulate a realistic EU policy process (e.g., Council negotiations, Parliamentary committee deliberations, Commission consultation procedures)
- Prepare a comprehensive lesson plan detailing the exercise structure, timing, and learning objectives
- Engage all class members as active participants with assigned roles
- Include all necessary supporting materials (role briefings, background documents, procedural guidelines)
- Connect directly to the week's readings and theoretical content
- Provide a clear learning outcome related to EU governance processes

Part 2: Lesson Plan and Materials Package Following the in-class exercise, each group must prepare:

- A revised version of the comprehensive lesson plan based on the in-class exercise in preparation for publication
- All supporting materials in a format that allows replication in other classroom contexts
- Clear facilitation guidelines for instructors
- A set of debrief questions to surface learning outcomes
- Reflection on what worked well and suggested improvements

Publication Opportunity The most effective and well-documented exercises will be selected for publication as open-access learning materials, providing students with the opportunity to contribute to EU studies pedagogy.

Assessment Criteria Groups will be assessed on:

- Quality and engagement of the in-class simulation
- Accuracy and relevance of EU process representation
- Clarity and completeness of materials package
- Effectiveness of facilitation and time management
- Potential for replication in other contexts

Topics will be assigned to groups at the beginning of the term, with each group receiving guidance on their specific policy area and relevant EU processes to simulate.

Diary study - ParliView platform

What is ParliView?

ParliView is an AI-powered transparency tool currently under development in UCD. It is designed to help citizens better understand what the European Parliament does. Using generative AI techniques, it transforms information from unwieldy online parliamentary databases into concise, user-friendly responses to user queries. ParliView seeks to make the vast amount of information about parliamentary activity genuinely accessible to citizens in simple, understandable language. The aim is to bridge the knowledge gap and improve trust in parliament, empowering citizens with clear insights into how their interests are represented in the EP.

The assignment

Assignment Overview: This assignment combines practical user experience research with reflection on the role of digital tools in political research. You will conduct a structured diary study while using the ParliView platform, documenting your experiences and insights over one week.

Learning Objectives

- Apply user experience research methods to evaluate digital political resources
- Critically assess the role of AI tools in accessing parliamentary data
- Develop systematic observation and documentation skills
- Reflect on the intersection of technology and political research

Timeline (7 Days)

- Day 1: Introduction session, access setup, initial exploration
- Days 2-6: Daily interaction tasks and diary entries
- Day 7: Final reflections and submission preparation

Diary Study Structure

Daily Tasks: Day 1: Getting Set Up

- Complete onboarding process and document your first impressions, noting any confusion points or particularly helpful features
- Conduct a 15-minute free exploration session to familiarise yourself with the interface, recording three initial observations about the platform's capabilities and limitations

Day 2: Information Retrieval

- Find specific information on a recently decided EU directive
- Document search strategies and platform responses

Day 3: Comparative Analysis

- Compare MEP positions across different member states on a single issue
- Note how the platform handles complex queries

Day 4: Historical Research

- Trace the evolution of EU policy on a topic over time
- Evaluate the platform's ability to provide chronological context

Day 5: Open Exploration

- Pursue your own research question using the platform
- Document unexpected findings or limitations

Day 6: Advanced Queries

- Test the platform's limits with complex, multi-part questions

- Attempt to verify information through alternative sources

Day 7: Reflection

- Review all diary entries and identify three recurring patterns in your interactions with the platform
- Create a priority list of five specific improvements based on your week's experience, ranking them by potential impact on user experience

Daily Diary Components For each session, record:

Pre-Session (2-3 minutes)

- Your goal for the session
- Expectations about what you'll find

During Session (throughout use)

- Screenshots of significant interactions
- Exact queries used and responses received
- Moments of confusion or clarity
- Time stamps for key events

Post-Session (5-10 minutes)

- Success in achieving your goal (scale 1-10)
- Key frustrations and breakthroughs
- Suggestions for improvement
- Reflections on the platform's understanding of your needs

Research paper

Student groups will submit a well-developed research paper examining the promises and pitfalls of AI tools and GovTech solutions as responses to the challenges of low knowledge of how the EU functions and declining institutional trust. Groups must identify, assess, and critically evaluate real tools currently in the public domain. This paper should be no longer than **5,000 words** including bibliography. The paper should be submitted in PDF format by **23:59pm on December 5th**.

Research Focus and Objectives

Your research should examine if and how digital governance technologies can address one or more of the following challenges:

- Public knowledge gaps about EU politics and decision-making processes
- Trust deficits between EU institutions and European citizens
- Information accessibility and democratic engagement with EU affairs
- The role of transparency tools in strengthening EU democratic legitimacy

Suggested Research Questions

Choose one primary research question to guide your analysis:

- Do current AI and GovTech tools deliver on their promises to improve EU political knowledge and institutional trust?
- What are the key limitations and unintended consequences of digital solutions to EU democratic engagement?
- How do different GovTech approaches compare in their effectiveness at addressing EU governance challenges?
- What factors determine whether AI-powered political tools succeed or fail in practice?
- Are digital solutions adequate responses to fundamental problems of EU democratic legitimacy?
- How do technological solutions compare with traditional approaches to civic engagement?

Required Research Components

Tool Identification and Selection Identify and select a real-world GovTech tool or set of tools currently available to the public that address EU governance challenges. These might include:

- Parliamentary transparency platforms and chatbots
- Citizen engagement and e-participation tools
- AI-powered policy analysis or legislative tracking systems
- Digital democracy and voter information platforms
- Government transparency and open data initiatives

Empirical Assessment Conduct hands-on evaluation of your selected tools, documenting:

- Tool functionality, user interface, and accessibility
- Effectiveness in achieving stated objectives
- User experience and potential barriers to adoption
- Quality and accuracy of information provided
- Technical limitations and performance issues

Critical Analysis: Promises vs. Reality Evaluate the gap between what these tools promise and what they deliver:

- Claims made by developers/institutions about the tool's impact
- Evidence of actual effectiveness in improving political knowledge or trust
- Unintended consequences or negative effects observed
- Sustainability and long-term viability of the solutions

Theoretical Framework Ground your analysis in relevant academic literature on:

- Democratic theory and the role of information in democratic processes
- Political trust and institutional legitimacy in the EU context
- Digital governance, e-participation, and civic technology research
- Technology adoption and digital divides in political contexts

Comparative Assessment Compare your selected tools with:

- Similar initiatives in other democratic contexts
- Alternative approaches to addressing the same problems
- Traditional methods of civic engagement and political information provision
- Best practices and lessons learned from successful implementations

Assessment Criteria

Papers will be evaluated on:

- Integration of theoretical frameworks with practical observations
- Comparative analysis and contextual understanding
- Quality of research methodology and evidence presentation
- Quality and depth of empirical assessment of selected tools
- Critical evaluation of promises versus reality
- Originality of insights and balanced argumentation
- Clarity of writing, structure, and practical relevance

Papers should demonstrate critical thinking and balanced analysis rather than purely descriptive accounts or uncritical acceptance of technological solutions. The analysis should contribute to understanding both the potential and limitations of AI and GovTech as responses to EU democratic challenges. Groups are strongly encouraged to discuss their tool selection and research approach with the instructor early in the semester.

Extension requests and late submission policy

You should make every effort to submit your work on time. If you are experiencing difficulties please contact the module coordinator at the earliest opportunity to discuss a possible extension.

To request an extension, students must use the following link ahead of the relevant deadline: https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSckaf0qepux0Estuh_JVMM9nY4v6BAiMYbqyVDmCceVkmang/viewform?usp=header

If you submit your essay late without prior notification to the module coordinator please refer to the University's Late Submission of Coursework Policy. The following penalties will apply:

- **1 week late (up to 5 working days after submission):**
 - Minus 1 grade point: A+ → A
- **2 weeks late (up to 10 working days past submission):**
 - Minus 2 grades: A+ → A-

Module readings

Required Readings:

The following text shall be used extensively throughout the module, so it is recommended that it is purchased:

- Cini, M. & Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. (2025). *European Union Politics*. 8th Edition. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Further reading:

In addition to the readings required for each topic, a series of recommended readings are also included in the syllabus. These readings will generally not be discussed in class, but are useful for those who wish to explore a particular topic in more detail. They will also be very useful when approaching the essay assignment, for which you are required to demonstrate a more in-depth understanding of your chosen topic.

The following are good general texts on the EU and EU politics.

- Nugent, N. (2006). *Government and Politics of the European Union*. 6th ed. Duke University Press.
- Peterson, J. & Bomberg, E. (1999). *Decision-Making in the European Union*. New York: St. Martin's Press.
- Peterson, J. & Shackleton, M. (2006). *The Institutions of the European Union*. 2nd ed. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Richardson, J. (2005). *European Union: Power and Policy-Making*. 3rd ed. London: Routledge.

- Bache, I. & George, S. (2006). *Politics in the European Union*. 2nd ed. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Moravcsik, A. (1998). *The Choice for Europe*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.
- Rosamond, B. (2000). *Theories of European Integration*. New York: St. Martin's Press.
- Cini, M. & Bourne, A.K. (2006). *Palgrave Advances in European Union Studies*. New York: Palgrave.
- Jorgensen, K.E., Pollack, M.A., & Rosamond, B. (2007). *The Handbook of European Union Politics*. New York: Sage Publications.

In addition to these readings, students should keep up to date on current European affairs by reading daily newspapers, or one of the many websites devoted to EU politics. These websites include the following:

- <http://www.euobserver.com>
- <http://europa.eu.int>
- <http://www.eupolitics.com>
- <http://www.ft.com>
- <http://blogs.lse.ac.uk/euoppblog/>
- <http://blogs.lse.ac.uk/brexit/>

Finally, each week a number of study questions are provided in order to guide your thinking about the topics being discussed and the required readings. These study questions will form the basis of the seminar topics covered and so careful consideration of the issues they raise should help you get to grasp with the issues being dealt with.

WEEKLY READING LIST

PART I: THE HISTORY AND THEORIES OF EUROPEAN INTEGRATION

Week 1: The Origins of the EU, and the development of Integration Theory.

Study question

- What are the main milestones that the integration process in Europe went through? How has the European integration project developed over time and how has the policy remit of the EU evolved?
- Why did neofunctionalists like Ernst Haas believe that the process of European integration, having begun so modestly, would snowball into an ongoing process of political integration? Are you convinced by the idea of spill-over effects proposed by the neofunctionalists as an explanation of the integration process?

- By the late 1950s, the neofunctionalist spill-over processes predicted by Ernst Haas seemed to be in full swing, only to be disrupted in the 1960s by French President Charles de Gaulle. Looking beyond the personality of de Gaulle, (1) analyze why the decades of the 1960s and 1970s appeared to have falsified Haas' neofunctionalism, and (2) assess whether the 1960s and 1970s were a period of progress, or rollback, or a mix of the two, in the integration process.
- Many saw the Single European Act (SEA) to be an effort to reinvigorate the integration process after several decades of stagnation, but the explanations for the SEA found in the required readings differ. What are the differences between the respective explanations for the SEA put forward by Zysman and Sandholtz and Moravcsik. Which argument is more persuasive, and why?
- Brexit is the first example of a member state trying to leave the EU. Can the existing theories of European integration shed light on the Brexit process and any likely outcomes?

Required Readings

- Hix, S. and Høyland, B. 2011. The political system of the European Union. Palgrave Macmillan. Chapter 1.
- Schmitter, P.C. (2006). Ernst B. Haas and the legacy of neofunctionalism. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 12(2): 255-272.
- Stone Sweet, A. & Sandholtz, W. (1997). European Integration and Supranational Governance. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 4(3): 297-317.
- Moravcsik, A. (1998). *The Choice for Europe*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press. Chapter 1.

Further reading

- Cini, M. & Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. (2025). *European Union Politics*. 8th Edition. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapters 1-5.
- Jones, E., Kelemen, R.D. and Meunier, S. 2016. Failing forward? The Euro crisis and the incomplete nature of European integration. *Comparative Political Studies*, 49(7), pp.1010-1034.
- Marks, G. (2011). Europe and Its Empires: From Rome to the European Union. *Journal of Common Market Studies*. 50(1): 1-20.
- Haas, E.B. (1958). *The Uniting of Europe*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- Hoffmann, S. (1966). Obstinate or Obsolete? The Fate of the Nation-State and the Case of Western Europe. *Daedalus*. 95(3).
- Deutsch, K.W. et al. (1957). *Political Community in the North Atlantic Area: International Organization in the Light of Historical Experience*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

- Diebold, W. (1959). *The Schuman Plan: A Study in Economic Cooperation, 1950-1959*. New York: Praeger.
- Haas, E.B. (1976). Turbulent Fields and the Theory of Regional Integration. *International Organization*. 30: 173-212.
- Monnet, J. (1978). *Memoirs*. New York: Doubleday.
- Moravcsik, A. *The Choice for Europe*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press. Chapter 2.
- Pollack, M.A. 2003. The Engines of European Integration: Delegation, Agency and Agenda Setting in the EU. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Pollock, M.A. 2005. Theorizing the EU: International Organization, Domestic Polity, or Experiment in New Governance? *Annual Review Political Science*. 8, pp.357–98.
- Rittberger, B. (2001). Which Institutions for Post-War Europe? Explaining the Institutional Design of Europe's First Community. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 8(5): 673-708.
- Caporaso, J. (1998). Regional integration theory: understanding our past and anticipating our future. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 5(1): 1–16.
- Mattli, W. (1999). Explaining regional integration outcomes. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 6(1): 1–27.
- Risse, T. (2005). Neofunctionalism, European identity, and the puzzles of European integration. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 12(2): 291–309.
- Corbett, R. (1987). The 1985 Intergovernmental Conference and the Single European Act. in Roy Pryce (ed.), *The Dynamics of European Union*. New York: Croom Helm.
- Tranholm-Mikkelsen, J. (1991). Neofunctionalism: Obstinate or Obsolete? *Journal of International Studies*. 20(1): 1-22.
- Moravcsik, A. (1993). Preferences and Power in the European Community: A Liberal Intergovernmentalist Approach. *Journal of Common Market Studies*. 31: 473–524.
- Bickerton, C.J., Hodson, D. and Puetter, U. 2014. The new intergovernmentalism: European integration in the post-Maastricht era. *Journal of Common Market Studies* 53(4), pp.703–22.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2015a. What's the news in 'new intergovernmentalism'? A critique of Bickerton, Hodson and Puetter. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies* 53(4), pp.723–30.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2015. Liberal intergovernmentalism and the euro area crisis. *Journal of European Public Policy*, 22(2), pp.177-195.

- Puetter, U. 2016. The centrality of consensus and deliberation in contemporary EU politics and the new intergovernmentalism. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(5), pp.601-615.
- Puetter, U. and Fabbrini, S. 2016. Catalysts of integration—the role of core intergovernmental forums in EU politics. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(5), pp.633-642.
- Kleine, M., and Pollack, M. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism and Its Critics. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1493–1509.
- Moravcsik, A. 2018. Preferences, Power and Institutions in 21st-century Europe. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1648-1674.
- Meunier, S., and Vachudova, M. A. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism, Illiberalism and the Potential Superpower of the European Union. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1631–1647.
- Hix, S. 2018. When Optimism Fails: Liberal Intergovernmentalism and Citizen Representation. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1595–1613.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism and the Crises of the European Union. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1578–1594.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2018. European integration (theory) in times of crisis. A comparison of the Euro and Schengen crises, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 25(7), pp.969-989
- Schmidt, V. A. 2018. Rethinking EU Governance: From Old to New Approaches to Who Steers Integration. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1544–1561.
- Naurin, D. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism in the Councils of the EU: A Baseline Theory?. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1526–1543.
- McNamara, K. R. 2018. Authority Under Construction: The European Union in Comparative Political Perspective. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1510–1525.
- Jones, E. 2018. Towards a theory of disintegration, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 25(3), pp.440-451.
- Rauh, C., 2019. Between neo-functionalist optimism and post-functionalist pessimism: Integrating politicisation into integration theory. Working paper.
- Genschel, P. and Jachtenfuchs, M., 2018. From market integration to core state powers: the Eurozone crisis, the refugee crisis and integration theory. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56(1), pp.178-196.

Week 2: Institutional change and Institutionalism

Study Questions

1. While the neofunctionalist-intergovernmentalist debate enlightened our understanding of the integration process, new theories of EU politics have since emerged focusing on institutions. What are these theories and what types of questions do they attempt to address?
2. How has the focus of the theoretical debate changed in light of these new institutionalist theories?
3. What do the different 'institutionalism' have in common and how do they differ?

Required Reading

- Aspinwall, M.D. & Schneider, G. (2000). Same menu, separate tables: The institutionalist turn in political science and the study of European integration. *European Journal of Political Research*. 38(1): 1–36.
- Tsebelis, G. & Garrett, G. (2001) The Institutional Foundations of Intergovernmentalism and Supranationalism. *International Organization*. 55(2): 357-90.
- Pierson, P. (1996). The Path to European Integration: A Historical Institutional Analysis. *Comparative Political Studies*. 29(2): 123-163.
- Checkel, J.T. & Moravcsik, M. (2001). A Constructivist Research Programme in EU Studies? *European Union Politics*. 2(2): 219-49.

Further reading

- Cini, M. & Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. (2025). *European Union Politics*. 8th Edition. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapter 7.
- Moravcsik, A. & Nicolaidis, K. (1998). Explaining the Treaty of Amsterdam: Interests, Influence, Institutions. *Journal of Common Market Studies*. 37: 59–85.
- Garrett, G. & Tsebelis, G. (1996). An Institutional Critique of Intergovernmentalism. *International Organization*. 50(02): 269–99.
- Hix, S. (1994). The Study of the European Community: The Challenge to Comparative Politics. *West European Politics*. 17: 1-30.
- Garrett, G. & Tsebelis, G. (1996). An Institutional Critique of Intergovernmentalism. *International Organization*. Vol. 50, No. 2, pp. 269-99.
- Christiansen, T., Jorgensen, K.E. & Wiener, A. (1999). The Social Construction of Europe. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 6: 528-44.
- Moravcsik, A. (1999). Is Something Rotten in the State of Denmark? Constructivism and European Integration. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 6(4).
- Checkel, J.T. & Moravcsik, A. (2001). A Constructivist Research Programme in EU Studies? *European Union Politics*. 2(2): 219-49.

- Jupille, J. & Caporaso, J.A. (1999). Institutionalism and the European Union: Beyond International Relations and Comparative Politics. *Annual Review of Political Science*. 2: 429–44.
- Aspinwall, M. & Schneider, G. eds. (2000). *The Rules of Integration: Institutional Approaches to the Study of Europe*. Manchester: Manchester University Press.

PART II: THE POLITICAL INSTITUTIONS OF THE EU AND ITS POLICY-MAKING PROCESS

Week 3: Negotiating the treaties

Study questions

- What are the sources of states' bargaining power during treaty negotiations? How do domestic constraints condition states' bargaining strength at IGCs?
- There is conflicting evidence regarding which players and what factors are most likely to affect the outcome of a treaty. What is the role of supranational actors in explaining IGC bargains?
- How has the Treaty of Lisbon shifted the EU's institutional balance of power between the major institutions of the EU?

Required Readings

- Dörfler, T., Holzinger, K., & Biesenbender, J. (2017). Constitutional Dynamics in the European Union: Success, Failure, and Stability of Institutional Treaty Revisions. *International Journal of Public Administration*, 1-13.
- Slapin, J. B. (2008). Bargaining power at Europe's intergovernmental conferences: testing institutional and intergovernmental theories. *International Organization*. 62(01): 131-162.
- Finke, D. (2009). Challenges to intergovernmentalism: an empirical analysis of EU treaty negotiations since Maastricht. *West European Politics*. 32(3): 466-495.

Further reading

- Slapin, J. B. (2006). Who is powerful? Examining preferences and testing sources of bargaining strength at European intergovernmental conferences. *European Union Politics*. 7(1): 51-76.
- Schneider, C. J. (2013). Globalizing electoral politics: Political competence and distributional bargaining in the European Union. *World Politics*, 65(3), 452-490.
- Johansson, K. M. (2016). The role of Europarties in EU treaty reform: Theory and practice. *Acta Politica*, 1-20.
- Panke, D. (2017). Speech is silver, silence is golden? Examining state activity in international negotiations. *The Review of International Organizations*, 12(1), 121-146.

- Finke, D., König, T., Proksch, S.O., & Tsebelis, G. (2012). *Reforming the European Union: realizing the impossible*. New Jersey: Princeton University Press.
- Slapin, J. B. (2009). Exit, voice, and cooperation: Bargaining power in international organizations and federal systems. *Journal of Theoretical Politics*. 21(2): 187-211.
- Finke, D. (2010). *European integration and its limits: intergovernmental conflicts and their domestic origins*. ECPR Press.
- Franchino, F. (2013). Challenges to liberal intergovernmentalism. *European Union Politics*. 14(2): 324-337.
- Finke, D. (2009). Domestic Politics and European Treaty Reform Understanding the Dynamics of Governmental Position-Taking. *European Union Politics*. 10(4): 482-506.
- Reinhard, J., Biesenbender, J., & Holzinger, K. (2014). Do arguments matter? Argumentation and negotiation success at the 1997 Amsterdam Intergovernmental Conference. *European Political Science Review*. 6(02): 283-307.
- Finke, D. (2013). Reforming International Institutions: The Domestic Origins and Conditional Logic of Governmental Reform Preferences. *International Studies Quarterly*. 57(2): 288-302.
- Reinhard, J. (2012). Because we are all Europeans! When do EU Member States use normative arguments?. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 19(9): 1336-1356.

Week 4: The EU as a Political System; the Commission and Executive Politics

Study Questions

1. Why do Member States choose to delegate policy-making powers to the supranational level? What types of problems does such delegation solve and what types of problems arise from the delegation decision?
2. Some recent studies find congruence between the Commission and member states' policy positions suggesting that the Commission might not be "completely independent in the performance of their duties" as specified in the treaty and not quite as supranational as it has been often portrayed. To what can we attribute this policy congruence? i.e., what are some of the key factors that constrain the Commission's independence and condition its policy positions, as identified in the readings?

Required Reading

- Cini, M. & Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. (2025). *European Union Politics*. 8th Edition. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapters 9-10.
- Pollack, M.A., (1997). Delegation, agency, and agenda setting in the European Community. *International Organization*. 51(1): 99-134.

- Wonka, A. (2007). Technocratic and Independent? The Appointment of European Commissioners and its Policy Implications. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 14(2): 169-89.
- Klüver, H., Mahoney, C. and Opper, M. (2015). Framing in context: how interest groups employ framing to lobby the European Commission. *Journal of European Public Policy*, 22(4), 481-498.

Further reading

- Egeberg, M. (2014). The European Commission: From agent to political institution. *Public Administration*, 92(1), 240-246.
- Ringe, N. (2005). Policy Preference Formation in Legislative Politics: Structures, Actors, and Focal Points. *American Journal of Political Science*. 49(4): 731-45.
- Thomson, R. (2008). National Actors in International Organizations: The Case of the European Commission. *Comparative Political Studies*. 41: 169-92.
- Hooghe, L. (2002). *The European Commission and the Integration of Europe*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Pollack, M.A. (2003). *The Engines of European Integration: Delegation, Agency and Agenda Setting in the European Union*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Egeberg, M. (2006). Executive Politics as Usual: Role Behaviour and Conflict Dimensions in the College of European Commissioners. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 13(1): 1-15.
- Franchino, F. (2009). Experience and the distribution of portfolio payoffs in the European Commission. *European Journal of Political Research*. 48(1): 1-30.
- Hooghe, L. (1999). Images of Europe: Orientations to European Integration Among Senior Officials of the Commission. *British Journal of Political Science*. 29: 345-367.
- Hooghe, L. (2002). *The European Commission and the Integration of Europe*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Hooghe, L. (2005). Several Roads Lead to International Norms, But Few via International Socialization: A Case Study of the European Commission. *International Organization*. 59: 861-898.
- Rasmussen, A. (2007). Challenging the Commission's Right of Initiative? Conditions for Institutional Change and Stability. *West European Politics*. 30(2): 244-64.
- Egeberg, M., Gornitzka, Å., & Trondal, J. (2014). A not so technocratic executive? Everyday interaction between the European Parliament and the Commission. *West European Politics*, 37(1), 1-18.
- Christensen, J. (2015). Recruitment and Expertise in the European Commission. *West European Politics*, 38(3), 649-678.

- Egeberg, M., Trondal, J., & Vestlund, N. M. (2015). The quest for order: unravelling the relationship between the European Commission and European Union agencies. *Journal of European Public Policy*, 22(5), 609-629.
- Wonka, A. (2008). ‘Decision-Making Dynamics in the European Commission: Partisan, National or Sectoral?’, *Journal of European Public Policy* 15(8), pp.1145–63.
- Hartlapp, M., Metz, J., & Rauh, C. (2014). *Which policy for Europe?: power and conflict inside the European Commission*. Oxford University Press.
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Week 5: Legislative Politics & Policy making (The Council of Ministers and the European Parliament)

Study Questions

1. Is the European Parliament a “normal” Parliament? In what sense is it “normal” and in what sense (if any) does it remain unique or sui generis? How has this changed over time as the EU has been reformed?
2. What drives policy outcomes in the Council of Ministers?
3. How is the impact of the Council, Parliament and Commission mediated through the institutional structure and rules of the decision-making process? What factors impact upon a legislative actor's ability to influence legislative outcomes?
4. How successful have the attempts to formally model the legislative process been at predicting legislative outcomes? Is this approach suitable for the task at hand? What aspects of the decision-making process might such models miss?
5. How might informal political arrangements reduce the difficulty associated with reaching agreements under more formal legislative procedures?

Required Reading

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Week 6: Judicial Politics

The ECJ, Judicial Politics and Compliance Study Question

1. Describe the powers of the ECJ. Do these powers make the ECJ an independent court? What limits (both formal and informal) exist on the powers of the ECJ?
2. What do we mean by the term “judicial activism”? Does the ECJ engage in judicial activism often? How have member states reacted to examples of judicial activism by the ECJ?
3. Carruba et al. and Stone Sweet & Brunell disagree on the extent to which member states can act collectively to constrain the ECJ. Which account of ECJ power and influence is more convincing and why?
4. We observe significant variation in the levels of compliance with EU law both between Member States and over time. What can explain this variation?

Required Readings

- Cini, M. & Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. (2025). *European Union Politics*. 8th Edition. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapter 12.
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Further reading

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- Hartlapp, M. 2018. Power Shifts via the Judicial Arena: How Annulments Cases between EU Institutions Shape Competence Allocation. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56: pp.1429–1445.

Week 7: Interest representation - Lobbying in Brussels

Study Question

- Describe the different access point through which lobbyists attempt to influence EU policy making. Do the institutional structures of the Commission, EP, and Council aid or hinder lobbyists in their lobbying attempts?
- What different types of factors have been identified as influencing lobbying success?
- What attempts have been made to regulate EU lobbying? Have these attempts been successful?

Key reading

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- Mahoney, C. & Baumgartner, F., (2008). Converging perspectives on interest group research in Europe and America. *West European Politics*. 31(6): 1253–1273.
- Mahoney, C. (2007). Lobbying Success in the United States and the European Union. *Journal of Public Policy*. 27(1): 35-56.
- Beyers, J. (2008) Policy Issues, Organizational Format and the Political Strategies of Interest Organizations. *West European Politics*. 31(6): 1188-1211.
- Beyers, J. & Kerremans, B. (2004). Bureaucrats, Politicians, and Societal Interests: How Is European Policy Making Politicized?" *Comparative Political Studies*. 37(10): 1119-1150.
- Börzel, T., Heard-Lauréote, K. (2009). Networks in EU Multi-level governance: Concepts and Contributions. *Journal of Public Policy*. 29(2): 135-152.
- Coen, D. (2007). Empirical and theoretical studies in EU lobbying. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 14(3): 333-345.
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- Greenwood, J. (2007b). Review Article: Organized Civil Society and Democratic Legitimacy in the EU. *British Journal of Political Science*. 37: 333-35.
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- Mahoney, C. (2008). *Brussels versus the Beltway. Advocacy in the United States and the European Union*. Washington DC: Georgetown University Press.
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Week 7 (second half of class): ParliView workshop

Goals

1. Complete the ParliView platform setup and onboarding process.
2. Begin your 7-day diary study with initial exploration of the platform's capabilities and limitations.
3. Document your first impressions and initial observations about AI-mediated access to parliamentary information.

Required Readings

- ParliView user agreement, user guide and platform documentation
- Diary study guidelines and requirements

Week 8: Reading week - no class

Week 9: Digital Europe and AI Governance

Study questions

- How has the EU's approach to digital governance evolved from market liberalism to digital sovereignty?
- What are the key elements of the EU's AI Act and how does it compare to other regulatory approaches globally?
- How do the Digital Services Act and Digital Markets Act reflect broader changes in EU governance philosophy?
- What challenges does the EU face in balancing innovation, competition, and digital sovereignty?

Key reading

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Further reading

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- Caliskan, E. & Rommerskirchen, C. (2024). Strange Bedfellows: Consumer Protection and Competition Policy in the Making of the EU Privacy Regime. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 62(5). DOI: 10.1111/jcms.13552
- Lahusen, C., Maggetti, M. and Slavkovik, M., 2024. Trust, trustworthiness and AI governance. *Scientific Reports*, 14(1), p.20752.

Week 10: The EU budget

Study questions

- What actors and institutions are involved in negotiating the EU budget?
- How are the powers of these actors to shape the EU budget influenced by the institutional rules structuring the budget-making process?
- How has the budget-making process in the EU evolved over time?

Required Readings

- Citi, M. (2015). European Union budget politics: Explaining stability and change in spending allocations. *European Union Politics*. 16(2). 260-280.
- Crombez, C. & Høyland, B. (2015). The budgetary procedure in the European Union and the implications of the Treaty of Lisbon. *European Union Politics*. 16(1): 67–89.
- Benedetto, G. (2017). Power, money and reversion points: the European Union's annual budgets since 2010. *Journal of European Public Policy*, 24(5), 633-652.
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Further reading

- Gehring, K. and Schneider, S.A. 2018. Towards the Greater Good? EU Commissioners' Nationality and Budget Allocation in the European Union. *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 10(1), pp.214-39.
- Dellmuth, L. M. & Stoffel, M. F. (2012). Distributive politics and intergovernmental transfers: The local allocation of European Union structural funds. *European Union Politics*. 13(3): 413–433.

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- Citi, M. (2013). EU budgetary dynamics: incremental or punctuated equilibrium?. *Journal of European Public Policy*. 20(8): 1157-1173.
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- Bojar, A. (2014). Intra-governmental bargaining and political budget cycles in the European Union. *European Union Politics*. 15(1): 132–151.
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- Goldbach, R. & Fahrholz, C. (2011). The euro area's common default risk: Evidence on the Commission's impact on European fiscal affairs. *European Union Politics*. 12(4): 507–528.
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Week 11: The Democratic Deficit, Democratic Legitimacy and Legislative Transparency

Study Questions

1. What is the EU's "democratic deficit"? What are the fundamental causes of this deficit, and why is it unlikely to be fixed in the near future? Why does Moravcsik argue that the EU is not particularly "broken" and so should not be "fixed"? Why, finally, do Follesdal & Hix believe that the democratic deficit is more serious than Moravcsik (and another analyst, Giandomenico Majone) thinks, and what do they recommend as to fix the problem? Which view do you find most convincing, and why?
2. The Laeken declaration (2001) states that: "the European project [...] derives its legitimacy from democratic, transparent and efficient institutions". At the same time, transparency is seen by Naurin as a necessary but not sufficient condition for democratic accountability in the European Union. How transparent is the EU in general and the legislative process in particular. Has this changed over time? What are the implications of the current levels of transparency in EU politics for the aforementioned democratic deficit? Finally, can the EU be simultaneously democratic transparent and efficient?

Required Readings

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Further reading

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Week 12: Brexit, public opinion, and the future of the EU

Study Questions

1. What drives public opinion about the EU? Can traditional explanations of public opinion help us understand the Brexit vote?
2. The balance of power in the Brexit negotiations is heavily in favour of the EU, why is this? What (if anything) might the UK be able to do to mitigate its disadvantaged bargaining position?
3. What are the implications of Brexit for the future of the EU?

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